

How does Edgar Allen Poe create tension in 'The Black Cat' and 'The Tell-Tale Heart'?

'The Black Cat' and 'The Tell-Tale Heart', published in 1843, remain Edgar Allen Poe's notable stories. He is a well-known author for innovative gothic stories that left a timeless mark on literature. His style and form of writing made him stand out the most from a popular genre of horror in the 19th century. Poe had two rules for every story written: read in one sitting, and every word must contribute to the story. Poe commands all the readers' attention and rewards us with the intense experience often called unity of effect. The stories use violence and horror to explore the paradoxes and mysteries of love, grief and guilt while resisting simple interpretations or clear moral messages. They often hint at supernatural elements when the true darkness they explore is the human mind and propensity for self-destruction. These gothic features are distinctive from any other gothic writers in literature. The following essay aims to show the ways of tension created between the two short stories with the frequent use of symbolic, literary techniques and Gothic elements.

Firstly, Poe creates tension in 'The Black Cat' through the characters' unpredictable actions. When alcohol dependence was initiated, our narrator often argued that one of the immoral actions was not his responsibility. For instance, 'The fury of a demon instantly possessed me.' The term 'possessed' suggests that his body is not under his control, as if a different force ('demon') took over his body and mind, further implying that this demonic power caused him to abuse this cat by removing an eye with a penknife. Alcohol became a critical entertainer in his life and led to domestic abuse. Very start of the story, the narrator expresses his love for his pets and how his wife brought him a bunch of pets. Abusing pets is perhaps a way of lashing at his wife and emotionally hurting her. The idea of motifs has one thing in common: the storyteller denies all responsibility for his activities. Yet, this makes the readers feel untrusted by his actions and causes tension as they are not ready for an unexpected move.

After killing and hanging the cat, his guilt still doesn't justify his actions by confessing, 'the spirit of PERVERSENESS ... '. Capitalization and hyperbole indicate the importance of 'perverseness', directing the reader to its significance in the story by proving his unethical actions and saying that is not fully sane. By this, the readers anticipate the character's every move. Besides, Poe's selection of words such as 'instantly fatal had it descended as I wished' heightens the murderer's thrill of committing a crime. At this point, the audience felt the slightest pity about his guilt. Due to his loved one's death and poor living life, Poe became an alcoholic himself. Critics often connected 'The Black Cat' story with Sigmund Freud's psychoanalysis theory. The narrator's aggression towards Pluto (the cat) is evident in that his love towards animals at a young age changed through which he finds pleasure in torturing animals. Desires and passions are part of our unconscious state of thinking which is difficult to hold and leads to instincts of attack according to Freud.

In "Tell-Tale Heart", Poe uses the environment to bring tension to the atmosphere. In the story, the narrator spies on the old man through the door, "His room was as black as pitch with the thick darkness, for the shutters were close fastened." The "thick darkness" and "shutters were closed fastened" make the reader feel claustrophobic and agitated though there is nowhere to escape. Atmospheric energy makes the readers feel trapped. Readers feel warned that something terrible might happen at night. Poe ensures that the darkness remains symbolic for the readers.

Moreover, Poe uses words to describe the sense of feeling and sight to describe a scene. For instance, the narrator waits in the doorway to startle the old man, "So I opened it you cannot imagine how stealthily, stealthily--until, at length, a single dim ray, like the thread of the spider, shot from out the crevice and fell full upon the vulture eye". The complex element compares the "single dim ray" to the "thread of a spider", creating a painful picture. The writer could easily compare the ray to something of positive intention behind it though, to correspond with gothic literature, he used the "thread of a spider." The "thread of the spider" and "vulture eye" are just two images among many others that Poe uses to stimulate his audience's senses. Poe's symbolism is darkness to portray the evilness in gothic literature but also the dark diction to emphasise the self-destructiveness of guilt and how it can fluctuate the confidence of a man. Poe's poems such as "Raven" show all the key events and settings that take place in the darkness, like in Tell Tale Heart. Generally, readers have a stereotyped view of darkness as it portrays an environment of scariness and unsafe in novels and films. Darkness was a common characteristic in Poe's life, critics argued that it represented his depression which motivated him to write spooky stories.

In both stories, Poe writes in first-person narration. The reader feels as though they are involved in the plot which enables them to feel a similar feeling to the narrator. From the very beginning of these stories, the reader knows what kind of story it's about to be as each narrator confesses how mad they were. Firstly, they begin to say that they are not insane regardless of what we think about them. In 'The Tell-Tale Heart' Poe writes 'You fancy me mad. Madmen know nothing', and in 'The Black Cat', 'Mad indeed would I be to expect it...' Yet mad I am not.' This type of confession at the story's start makes Poe's writing style unique. Poe often invites the readers to save our narrators as they introduce and make us feel that the narrator requires our help out of the madness. This familiarises the reader that in every Edgar Allan Poe story, the narrator does not believe in himself and convinces the reader that I am not mad by nature but can explain why he became insane. This is a way of reinforcing tension in readers as it puts the readers in a dilemma of what to expect from this kind of character.

Another shared idea in both stories is the symbolism of eyes. In 'The Black Cat', the first instinct of the narrator is to remove an eye from the cat; however, in 'The Tell-Tale Heart', the old man's eyes are paranoid. The eyes are the reflection of a human's personality and honesty. Still, in gothic nature, the eyes are noticeable as the medallion of many of the haunting figures in the stories. In 'The Tell-Tale Heart', The description of the old man's eyes links with "the eye of a vulture – a pale blue eye, with a film over it". The vulture's eyes are a sign of the inevitability of

death. For the protagonist to describe the eyes as being like 'vulture' eyes, it's relevant when examining the option that the protagonist may have viewed the eye as an unwanted reminder of death and of being mortal. Meanwhile, In 'The Black Cat', the eyes are an age-old symbol of the soul. This can be seen in "The socket of the lost eye presented, it is true, a frightful appearance,..." Metaphorically, the cutting of one of the cat's eyes emphasises that the narrator effortlessly separates his soul into two by destroying half of it. This reinforces the narrator's duality and it gives us an image of the ruin of his good half.

To conclude, Poe's exceptional writing style makes both stories engaging and complements the genre written. These short stories as a film can't do much justice to the genre yet the stories left a powerful mark with intensifying atmosphere and symbolism in every audience's mind. Both stories were written more than 100 years ago, in 1843. This 1900s writing inspires today's writers to write more gothic stories. Poe's skills and language made the stories chilling and joyful to read which sums up why these stories effectively created tension.